

Chapter 16

Dealing with Problem Situations

When leading groups, a leader must be prepared to deal with any number of situations. In this chapter, we identify many of the most common problems that arise and provide examples to illustrate some skills and techniques for handling these situations. We have identified the following 13 common problems:

1. The chronic talker
2. The dominator
3. The distracter
4. The rescuing member
5. The negative member
6. The resistant member
7. The member who tries to "get the leader"
8. Dealing with silence
9. Dealing with sexual feelings
10. Dealing with crying
11. Dealing with mutually hostile members
12. Asking a member to leave
13. Dealing with prejudiced, narrow-minded, or insensitive members

The Chronic Talker

It is not difficult to spot the chronic talker. He is often characterized by persistent rambling and repetition. When a chronic talker is present, other members who have concerns that they would like to discuss are prevented from doing so. Soon the group members either tune out the chronic talker and lose interest in the proceedings or get frustrated and angry with both the talkative member and the leader. Depending on the reason underlying his talkativeness, the chronic talker falls into three different types: the nervous member, the rambler, and the show-off.

1. *The nervous member* talks to hide his feelings of nervousness or as a means of self-control. Easily recognized, the nervous member is often the first one to answer questions posed by the leader and the first to volunteer for some task. Because the nervous member is talking to alleviate anxiety, he will talk frequently and for as long as the leader lets him.
2. *The rambler* dominates discussions because she is simply a talkative person and is unaware of the effect her rambling has on others. She is also easily recognized because she tells long, drawn-out stories and sometimes repeats herself. The stories are often trivial and are not usually meaningful to others.
3. *The show-off* is a talkative person because he is insecure and wants to impress the group leader, other members, or both. The show-off seems to be attempting to show others what he knows. In doing so, he answers all questions, asks irrelevant questions in an effort to grab the leader's attention, and may offer unsolicited advice to other group members. The other members often resent this and grow to dislike this type of member. The problem with the show-off is that he can quickly divert the group from its intended purpose.

Handling the Talkative Member

To determine whether or not a member should be seen as a chronic talker, the leader should consider the following questions:

- For how long has the member been talking?
- How many comments has the member made compared with other group members?
- Are the member's comments in line with the intended purpose of the group?
- Is this member preventing others from talking?
- Are others becoming bored or irritated with the member's comments?
- Does the member seem to be talking because of nervousness or a desire to impress others?

There are several ways to handle a talkative member. For example, upon recognizing such a member, the leader could have members form dyads, making sure she pairs herself with the talkative member. In the dyad, the leader could attempt to speak to the member about his talkativeness. The advantage of this strategy is that the talkative member receives the message about his talkativeness from only one person, thus causing less embarrassment.

There are a couple of strategies that involve the whole group. One is to address the group with the hope that the talkative member hears the message. The other strategy involves seeking feedback from the members.

■ EXAMPLES

It is early in the life of the group, and the leader wants to curb the rambler's talking but at the same time not seem critical of the member. Therefore, the leader decides to deliver the message to the entire group by looking at everyone as she speaks.

LEADER: It is important to keep in mind that the purpose of the group is for *everyone* to share thoughts and feelings. If any one member gets too long-winded, the focus of the group changes from sharing to listening to one member. Please be aware of how much you are talking, and whether or not you are dominating the discussion.

■ ■ ■

In this example, the leader introduces a feedback exercise because she believes members want to confront the talkative member.

LEADER: As I stated in the beginning of this group, one of the most potentially helpful aspects of a group such as this is for members to receive feedback about themselves from other members of the group. In effect, this feedback acts as a mirror, letting you know how others in the group see and react to you. Is there anyone here who would like to give another member some feedback?

The leader would use this kind of opening to a feedback exercise only if she were confident that members wanted to share their feelings about a member's excessive talking. If the leader felt that members would not speak up unless the leader did, a feedback exercise could be devised in which the leader could also give feedback to the rambling member. Sometimes members will offer feedback without being prompted to do so. When this happens, the leader merely needs to make sure that the member receiving the feedback doesn't feel attacked.

■ ■ ■

If the leader is about to ask the group a question and is sure that a talkative member will again speak up and attempt to dominate the discussion, the leader might say something like, "I'm going to ask a question, and I would like to hear from some of you who haven't talked yet." The leader should say this while avoiding eye contact

with the talkative member. These techniques may stop the dominating member and draw out comments from members who have been silent. At times the leader unknowingly perpetuates a particular member's talking by maintaining eye contact with him and nodding her head as that member speaks. Maintaining eye contact usually reinforces the member's talking.

One direct way of intervening with the talkative member is to speak to the member immediately after the session or sometime before the next session about his excessive talking.

EXAMPLE

LEADER: *(Talking to a member after the session has ended)* Wanda, tell me if I'm wrong, but you seemed a bit nervous during the group tonight. You were repeating yourself a lot as you talked, and you talked very rapidly.

WANDA: Yes, you're right. I was hoping that no one would notice. I just get uptight every time I'm around a new group of people. It is something that I definitely want to work on.

■ ■ ■

Another strategy that could be used if the leader were having the members turn in any kind of written reactions to the group would be to give the member feedback in writing. (In therapy and growth groups, members often write a brief reaction at the end of each session.) For example, the leader might write the following feedback at the bottom of the member's reaction:

> Tom, I sense that you are uncomfortable because you talked quite a bit and at a very rapid pace. I am hoping that you will be a little more comfortable and thus talk a little less. Let me know if there is anything that we can do to help you feel more comfortable.

Members usually receive this message very well and become more cognizant of their talkative behavior. In addition, a note such as this often helps members feel more comfortable about talking to the leader outside the group. This is a nonthreatening way to offer feedback; however, there is no guarantee that the member receiving the feedback will respond favorably to it, and if the member reads it somewhere outside the group, no one will be there to help process the feedback.

■ ■ ■



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Dealing with a Talkative Member

Review video 8.2 and watch how the leader has to twice deal with the very talkative member.

The Dominator

The dominator is a member who tries to rule the group. This member is different from the chronic talker because this person wants to run things and be in control. This kind of member is fairly common in residential treatment settings and in school groups. In education, discussion, or task groups, a dominator is often present. The leader should try some of the different techniques suggested for dealing with the chronic talker; however, the leader quite often needs to meet with this kind of member privately to discuss his behavior in the group. Sometimes this kind of member can be used as a helper or be given a role that makes him feel special. Other times, the behavior is such that he has to be asked to leave the group because he is not willing to give control to the leader.

The Distracter

The distracter is a member who is either seeking attention or is avoiding looking at herself. To accomplish this, she tries to get the group off task by bringing up unrelated subjects or asking questions that are not relevant. Some distracters make noises or move around as a way to distract members. This person is often found in school or residential groups and in groups that are not voluntary. Sometimes this member is very difficult to deal with because she is not intentionally trying to distract the group. Talking with the member and then ignoring her comments or behaviors often helps to minimize the effects of the distracter.

The Rescuing Member

Rescuing is the attempt of a member to smooth over negative feelings experienced by another member of the group. When a member becomes upset, often other group members attempt to soothe the member with such statements as, "Now, don't worry, it will be all right" or "Everything has a way of working itself out if you just give it time." This is usually not helpful, and such comments often sound patronizing. Rescuing can prevent the member in pain from problem solving.

EXAMPLES

One of the members, Judy, cries as she tells the group about her upcoming divorce. As she does so, another member, Karen, attempts to rescue her.

KAREN: Don't worry Judy, everything will be okay. I went through a divorce myself, and you just have to make the best of it. I think ...

LEADER: *(Interrupting Karen in mid-sentence)* Judy, you are in a lot of pain right now, and if you would like, we can listen and try to be of help. By sharing, I think you will at least get some of your thoughts out, and I think that you will feel our support. *(Judy nods that she would like to.)*

LEADER: *(After Judy has discussed her divorce and using a kind voice)* I'd like to say something to all of you here. Usually when a member is struggling with some issue like a divorce, she doesn't need our sympathy or advice as much as she needs to be listened to and supported.

Members often think they are being supportive when, in fact, they are trying to rescue the member. Teaching members how helping and sharing differ from rescuing is important as the group progresses. In the early life of the group, the leader may need to intervene quite often, because group members are not aware of their rescuing behaviors. In the preceding example, the leader decides to convey the message about sympathy being unhelpful to the entire group so that they could observe her modeling the correct method of being therapeutic in the group.

■ ■ ■

This group is a stress management group composed of first-year teachers. One of the members, Vivian, is upset with her husband. Another member hears this and gives her sympathy and pity.

VIVIAN: It is so stressful being a first-year teacher and juggling all the things with the kids and the house. My husband is always on me about the house and the kids, but it is hard to get it all done. I am trying but sometimes I just can't get to the laundry or the cleaning, and then he doesn't have a shirt to wear. I feel so bad. I feel so lucky to have met such a good person who doesn't drink or yell that often. I just feel like a failure on all fronts—I am not pleasing him, and I am not being a good mom or a good teacher. *(Starts to tear up)*

ROSE: Vivian, things will get better. The school year is nearly half over and we all will know so much more about teaching next year. I think you're doing a good job. I like teaching with you when we have those joint classes. Don't the rest of you think Vivian is a good teacher?

LEADER: *(With a slow, kind voice)* Wait just a second. I don't think this is really about whether Vivian is a good teacher, but more about the self-talk that is going on in her head. Vivian, would you like to understand more about where your stress is coming from?

■ ■ ■

The Negative Member

A negative member is one who constantly complains about the group or disagrees with other members of the group. Negative members are particularly troublesome because their attitude and behavior counter the leader's goal of maintaining a positive working tone. If one or two members are negative and begin to complain, other members will sometimes join in and also become negative. The group sessions may become gripe sessions, and very little is accomplished.

There are three possible strategies for dealing with the negative member:

1. Talk to the person outside the group and attempt to establish why he is so negative. The leader can even ask for the member's cooperation in making the group productive. Sometimes such members simply want the leader's attention or a role to play in the group. By talking to the member, the leader can offer a positive role to the negative member.
2. Identify the allies (positive group members) in the group and direct questions and comments to them. Getting these members to talk more than the negative members can help to establish a more positive tone in the group.
3. When asking the group a question, avoid eye contact with the negative person so that you do not draw her out.

Leaders should usually avoid confronting a negative member in front of the other group members. This confrontation can turn into an argument between the leader and the negative member, which would not be productive for the other group members. If the leader finds herself in any kind of argumentative situation, she should shift the focus to another person or topic and then talk to the negative member at the end of the group.

It is important to understand that groups will at times have one or two negative members. This is especially true at the beginning of a group and particularly so if the group is a mandatory one. Many times negativism diminishes as the group becomes more interesting. However, there will be times when, no matter what the leader does, a member will remain negative. In extreme cases, it may be necessary to ask the member to leave the group or to sit quietly. Leaders often devote far too much time trying to work with a negative member while ignoring those members who are interested in the group.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Dealing with Negative Members

Review video 1.1 and watch how the leader dealt poorly with negative members. Then watch 1.2 and see how the leader better handled negative members.

The Resistant Member

Some members are resistant because they are forced to be in the group. Sometimes these members will work through their resistance if they are given a chance to express their anger. This situation is difficult for the leader, because he does not know whether allowing the member to express anger will be of benefit or if the member will merely complain and set a negative tone for the group. However, it is essential for the leader to pay attention when a member is seemingly working through her resistance.

Four examples of resistant members would be:

1. The member who, during the first meeting, says he does not know why he has to be at the meeting and does not see how the group can be helpful
2. The member who comes and sits with her arms crossed and does not contribute unless forced to—and then says as little as possible
3. The member who always tries to focus the group on topics not relevant to the group, such as movies, sports, or the latest fashions
4. The member who is not resisting the group but is resistant to changing something about himself

Some members have negative expectations about the effectiveness of a group. These members believe that the group will not be helpful, and therefore, they refuse to participate cooperatively. If the leader is faced with a resistant member, her two primary strategies are to let the member share his feelings in the group, or to talk to him in a dyad, or after the session, and try to help him work through his resistance. If neither of these works and the member has to remain in the group because of the setting (such as a residential treatment center), the leader will want to be sure *not* to focus on that member. A common mistake of leaders is to devote as much as half of each session trying to break down members' resistance.

Sometimes a resistant member appears to be opposed to the leader's attempt to be helpful but not to the members' attempts. If this seems to be the case, the leader may want to set up situations in which the member can share with other members of the group. This can be done through the use of dyads, triads, and small-group discussions without the direct participation of the leader. Or if the member is the focus of the group, the leader lets the members do the majority of the helping.

Conversely, the resistant member may oppose the attempts of the members to be helpful but not the leader's attempts. If this is the case, individual counseling within the group or privately may be the best way to help the member.

It is important that the leader distinguish between the member who is resisting the group process and the member who is resistant because she does not want to change something about herself or her situation.

EXAMPLE

Angela has been discussing being a mother and having a career. She has stated that she wants to continue her career but doesn't know what to do with her children during the day.

JACKIE: Could you leave them at a day care center?

ANGELA: Yes, but I'm not so sure that is a good place for them.

TODD: Does your company have a program for taking care of employees' children?

ANGELA: Yes, but I don't like some of the children and workers there.

FRANCES: Do you have relatives nearby who would be willing to care for them?

ANGELA: Yes, but I hate to impose.

In a case like this, the leader should realize that the member is resistant to or hesitant about hearing suggestions. One way to deal with this resistance would be to say something like the following:

LEADER: Angela, I think we understand the concern, but I am not sure how we can be of help here in the group. What would be helpful to you?

■ ■ ■

Another way to handle resistance in many groups is to focus on the resistant member in an indirect manner, as described in Chapter 14. That is, the leader may work with a more willing member with the intent of helping the resistant member learn something by watching. Conducting therapy in this manner takes the direct focus off the resistant member. The important thing to remember is not to spend too much time with the resistant member if it takes productive time away from the other group members.

The Member Who Tries to "Get the Leader"

When leading a group, a leader needs to be prepared for what we call "get the leader." This occurs when a member attempts to sabotage what the leader is saying or doing in the group. Get the leader can take the form of disagreeing with the leader, not following through with instructions given by the leader, asking unanswerable questions to make the leader look bad, or talking to others while the leader is talking. This member is different from the negative member in that the member is truly after the leader.

There are a variety of reasons for members to want to get the leader. Often the reasons can be traced to something said or done by the leader that caused the member to become irritated or embarrassed. The following

is a list of some leader behaviors that might cause members to want to get the leader:

- Putting a member on the spot in front of the other members
- Cutting off a member inappropriately (or even appropriately)
- Not giving a member the chance to talk or failing to recognize when a member wants to speak
- Telling a member that the group will come back to his issue or concern, and then failing to do so
- Allowing the group members to offer too much negative feedback to a particular member
- Not being skilled enough to control the group
- Allowing the group to be boring because of the leader's lack of skill

Although the leader is often the cause of get-the-leader behavior in the group, there are other possible causes.

- Members who are not self-referred sometimes take out their frustrations and anger on the leader.
- Members sometimes project their fears about being in the group onto the leader.
- Members who have struggled in their relationships with authority figures might attempt to spoil the leader's efforts.
- Members sometimes want to be the leader's "favorite" and react angrily when they don't feel that they are.

Probably the first thing a leader should do when she realizes that a member is trying to get her is to shift the focus away from any power struggle between the member and herself.

EXAMPLES

LEADER: I'd like us to begin today's session by talking about how drinking has affected your family life.

JOE: Why do you always pick the topics? I thought this was *our* group. Tell me!

LEADER: *(Speaking in a calm voice while making eye contact with all the members, using no extra eye contact with Joe in order to try to discourage Joe from additional comments)* Let me explain to all of you how I decide on the topics. Also, be aware that if there is a topic or something that you would like to discuss, you can let me know. There are a number of topics that I feel we should cover....

LEADER: I would like each of you to close your eyes and try to imagine that...

LYNN: *(Interrupting)* Are you going to do another one of those stupid fantasy exercises? What good are they?

LEADER: Lynn, feel free to sit quietly. *(To the other members)* I want you to close your eyes and imagine that you are an animal....

■ ■ ■

Once the leader has sidestepped the member's attempt to get him, he should try to understand why the member has targeted him. Often, the leader knows why it happened, and if the problem can be corrected by such techniques as paying more attention to the member, going back to the member's issue, or making sure not to put the member on the spot, then the leader should make the correction. If the leader does not understand why the member has targeted him, he might choose to pair up in a dyad with the member or talk to the member at the end of the session to see if he can gain some information. He might say something like, "Something seems to be going on between you and me. Is it anything I said or did that upset you?"

If the member does not want to share his thoughts, the leader might be able to gain some insight from talking to other members. Often a member will share disgruntled thoughts with a fellow member but not with the leader. If the leader seeks information from other members, he must be very careful to ensure that the members do not feel any pressure to share something they feel they should not share. This may happen in school or residential settings where the counselor interacts with the members on a regular basis.

If a member persists in trying to sabotage the leader and the leader has talked to the member, the leader may get help from the group by asking for feedback about the member's complaints or behavior. The leader would do this only if he knew he had the support and understanding of all, or nearly all, the other members. The leader could ask the entire group, "Do you like the way the group is going and the activities I ask you to do?" Or he could be more specific: "I would like some feedback. Whenever I suggest anything, Cleve always wants to argue with or question me. How do the rest of you feel about Cleve's doing that?" Assuming the leader receives a favorable response from either of these feedback questions, the member should see that he is alone in his attacks or that the other members are annoyed with his behavior.

We hope this discussion has alerted you to the existence of this phenomenon and has given you some ways of dealing with it. Too many beginning leaders fail to recognize "get the leader" and misread it as resistance or negativism, when in fact it is something that they either caused or can change with a slight adjustment. However, there are times when there is almost nothing the leader can do to stop the member other than removing that member from the group.

Dealing with Silence

There are both productive and nonproductive silences in a group. Productive silence occurs when members are internally processing something that was said

or done in the group. Nonproductive silence occurs when members are quiet because they are confused about what to say, fearful of talking, or bored. When the group is silent, the leader should ask herself if the silence is productive. The leader can usually tell by observing the members' reactions as they are sitting there and also by considering what has just occurred in the group. If the members seem deep in thought as a result of someone's intense work, the silence should be allowed. Sometimes the leader may allow the silence to last for 1 or 2 minutes if it appears to be productive. The leader may choose to wait until someone else breaks the silence, or she may choose to break the silence by saying something like, "Many of you seem to really be thinking about what just happened. I'd like you to briefly share your thoughts." However, if the members are silent because they are not interested, then the silence should signal the leader to change the focus or address the group about their lack of interest.

Sometimes members are silent at the beginning of a session because they are not yet warmed up to the session. It can be a mistake to let silence occur at the beginning of the session, because what the members really need is some discussion or activity to get them started. This goes back to what we have said about the importance of leading the group rather than waiting for the members to take charge. Sometimes the wait is very long and not productive.

If the members have nervous or blank looks on their faces, wondering who will start, we suggest that the leader break the silence after 15 or 20 seconds to get the group started. Some experts feel very differently about this and let a group sit in silence for 5 to 10 minutes in the belief that the members should be responsible for what happens in the group. For the most part, we have found this to be counterproductive. In groups where this has occurred, many members have reported that they were confused about what was going on and were bored sitting there waiting for something to happen. It can also promote verbal attacks among members. We feel that in situations where the members are not really thinking, the group time usually can be better spent when the leader breaks the silence with a question, a round, or an exercise that is relevant and productive.

When the leader feels the silence is being very productive and a member starts to speak, the leader can say to the member, "Let's wait just a few more seconds. People seem to really be thinking."

Dealing with Sexual Feelings

Sometimes group members are sexually attracted to other members, especially in therapy, growth, and support groups where members share on a personal level. Certain group dynamics may emerge when this occurs. Members may try to impress each other; they may hold back sharing because of another; or they may become jealous, hurt, or angry at what another member is sharing. These kinds of dynamics can be detrimental to the group process, but a leader must keep in mind that sexual attraction can and will occur. There is nothing the leader can do about it, and, in fact, leaders will not want to act as moral legislators. Some

leaders set a rule that members cannot relate to one another outside the group. Our observation is that members are going to do this regardless of the rule, so a better strategy is to talk about how this can become a problem.

At times members form relationships that do not interfere with the group; other times outside relationships do cause problems. If a situation has arisen that is hindering the group (such as two people dating or one person being interested in another member who is not reciprocating), the leader may choose to talk privately to the person or persons involved about possible solutions to the problem. Other times, the issue can be brought up in the group, especially if other members feel that the relationship is disrupting the group in some way. This may not be easy to handle, but the leader should not ignore these situations. Sometimes, having one of the members drop out of the group is the best solution.

Dealing with Crying

Members may cry at any time during the group. They may cry when they or someone else talks about topics such as low self-esteem, abuse, the death of a loved one, a divorce of their own or of their parents, the loss of a job, an illness, or moving from one place to another. The tears may range from moisture in the eyes (tearing up) to uncontrollable sobbing and may indicate a range of emotions from sadness to fear, anger, depression, emptiness, confusion, anxiety, and even happiness.

Some leaders who notice that a member is starting to cry immediately try to help the member with the pain before getting a contract to do so. Often, members are not ready to discuss what they are feeling, so when the leader tries to help those not ready to share, the member feels pressure, which may lead to resentment. The leader should always be sure the member wants to work on the problem and that there is enough time to adequately deal with the emotions of the member. A common mistake that beginning leaders make when they notice a member tearing up is to focus on that member without considering how much time is left in the session. They then find themselves having to cut short the work with that person in order to end the session at the designated stopping time. Naturally, if someone is in pain, the leader will want to be sensitive to that person, but he also needs to be aware of the time.

If time is not a factor, the leader may pair up with the member in pain to find out more about the pain. To occupy the other members, the leader would have them get into dyads and process what they were just discussing or some other topic that the leader thinks is relevant. The leader could also acknowledge the pain and suggest to the member that they talk after the group.

Another important consideration when a member is crying is whether the crying is a result of some struggle or painful event or is an attempt to gain sympathy. Some group members naturally feel sorry for the person and reach out and touch the person who is crying. Members can usually not distinguish who is genuinely struggling with some painful issue and who wants to be rescued.

Often, it is appropriate to ask a member not to touch or hug another member who is feeling sorry for himself or playing a "poor-me" game. Hugging or touching that member would not be therapeutic.

In some groups, such as educational or discussion groups or even some experiential groups, dealing for any length of time with a member in psychological pain is not appropriate. If the leader observes that someone is beginning to cry, he may want to shift the focus away from that member and then seek her out after the group. Or the leader may want to say something like, "Martina, I can see that you are in some pain. Let's talk after the group." When leading education, discussion, or task groups, beginning leaders often make the mistake of holding the focus on the person in pain, thus creating confusion in the members who are expecting a different kind of group. In a therapy group where crying is appropriate, the leader may say something like: "I notice you are tearing up/crying; is there something you would like to work on in group today?"

EXAMPLES

This group is composed of cancer patients. One of the members, Wanda, is discussing her failing health.

WANDA: Some days are better than others. I try to keep a positive attitude about the whole thing, and I succeed if I feel good that day. Today, I've felt bad. *(She begins to cry.)* It's on these days that I wonder if I'm gonna make it.

JERRY: *(Sitting next to her, he puts his arm around her shoulders and attempts to comfort her.)* Wanda, let it out if you need to. I don't think it helps to always try to keep up a positive image.

In this example, Wanda was genuinely struggling with a life-and-death issue. It is perfectly acceptable for Jerry to touch her.

■ ■ ■

LESLIE: *(In a little girl voice)* They just never let me grow up. Just like this past Christmas. I wanted to go to the mountains to ski, but my mother said that I should come home because my grandparents were going to be there. They make me so mad. *(Starts to cry)* And they also hurt my feelings. My dad said that I was selfish and that I only think of myself. I just wish they would learn to accept me and stop trying to make me a clone of them. *(Carey starts to put her arm around Leslie.)*

LEADER: *(In a calm, soft voice)* Carey, don't do that. Leslie, I am wondering if we can get the thinking part of you to deal with this issue? Right now, I sense that you are coming more from the hurt, angry part.

■ ■ ■

One of the biggest mistakes that leaders make when a member begins to cry over some painful issue is to allow the other group members to ask a series of irrelevant questions. In the last example, some members might have responded to Leslie's statement in the following ways:

- Where do your parents live?
- How many grandchildren do your grandparents have?
- How often do you visit?

Group members can divert the central focus of the group by asking such irrelevant and untimely questions, often out of discomfort and a desire to stop the crying. When this occurs, the leader must step in and cut off the questions.

A member may also start to cry during the first or second session, before the group is ready to deal with an intense emotional concern. Many times a member will be ready to delve into his concern. However, the leader needs to be careful in this situation, because sometimes members become frightened by the emotional intensity and do not return. During the first and second sessions, a leader should be cautious about how much pain and emotion she lets members express. If the majority of the group seems ready, then it can be valuable to let a member get into his intense pain.

Dealing with Mutually Hostile Members

In any kind of group, there is the possibility of a member disliking another member. This dislike may manifest itself in arguments, disagreements, and silence between members. Sometimes members begin the group disliking each other because of something that happened before the group began. If possible, this should be checked out by the leader during the screening interview by asking, "Is there anyone whom you dislike and would not want to be in the group with you?" However, this is not a foolproof method for preventing members from disliking each other because even members who do not know each other at the beginning of the group can quickly grow to dislike each other as the group progresses. When this occurs, the leader may want to address the issue in the group if she feels that such a discussion would be beneficial. Often members' behavior within the group is indicative of their behavior outside the group. Thus, focusing on the process of how members came to dislike each other can be one of the most beneficial discussions for them in terms of helping them become more accepting of others in their daily lives. Helping members come to terms with each other can also potentially be one of the most productive processes for solidifying the group and building group cohesion. However, there will be times when, no matter what happens in the group, members will not overcome their personal dislike for each other. Rather than getting members to like each other, the goal is to get the members not to let their dislike for another completely interfere with their benefiting from the group experience.

If the leader decides to focus on a major conflict between two members during a group session, we suggest that the leader meet privately with each of the conflicting members to identify the issues clearly and explain the reason for wishing to deal with it in the group. This individual contact between the leader and each member should also be used to build additional rapport and enlist the cooperation of the members. Without getting a commitment from each member to work toward a resolution of the issue, the leader is setting the stage for a potential disaster. If the leader confronts the members unexpectedly, either or both members may use the group as a major battleground.

■ EXAMPLE

Two members of a group in a residential treatment center for adolescents are in a power struggle over control issues in the center. The leader has the option of switching either member into another therapy group but decides to try to help them work on their issues. The leader meets with each member individually and then opens the session as follows:

LEADER: Today I'm hoping we can spend some time dealing with an issue that's important to all of us. As you know, Jack and Phillip have had some problems with each other. I talked to each of them and got them to agree to try and work some things out in the group. *(The leader then turns to the two members to get confirmation.)*

JACK: Yeah, I agree to try.

PHILLIP: It's okay with me.

LEADER: Okay, I guess I'd like to start by asking the rest of you what you see as the cause of the problems between Jack and Phillip.

MOE: They each think they are right and can't stand it if the other is right.

PETE: They are always trying to one-up each other. Jack is a pretty good listener when anyone but Phillip is talking. When Phillip talks, Jack, you don't listen to him at all.

JACK: He doesn't listen to me. When I was talking about my dad, he said I was stupid!

LEADER: So wait a minute. Some of your anger, Jack, is over the thing Phillip did when you were talking about your dad? How do others of you deal with someone who has done something upsetting to you?

In this example, the leader chooses to allow the other members to provide feedback and will gradually involve these two members as the discussion continues. Instead of focusing on specific complaints, focusing on the general topic of conflict resolution and ways of dealing with anger may be the most productive direction. Later in the session, examples provided by the two members in conflict may be used to demonstrate how differences can be handled. The leader is not avoiding the conflict between these members by this approach.

On the contrary, the leader is assuming they lack good techniques for resolving their power struggle and must be taught such techniques before their efforts can be successful.

■ ■ ■

When members don't like each other, the leader may be able to prevent any further growth of animosity by using dyads and exercises. Placing members who dislike each other in pairs or having them complete an exercise together may only serve as a battleground for their dislike toward one another. On the other hand, forcing antagonistic members to work together may help them bridge their differences. Sometimes leaders find it effective to pair the two members who dislike each other and then join the dyad to help them talk through their dislikes.

If the dislike is so great that it is interfering with the group, one or both members should be removed from the group if possible and placed in a different group. In addition, if this type of behavior seems to be a pattern for a particular member, perhaps the member is not ready for a group and would benefit more from individual counseling.

Asking a Member to Leave

Although asking a member to leave the group is not a regular occurrence, it is an option that leaders need to understand and be willing to implement. There are several reasons a leader would ask a member to leave, such as being very negative, hostile, or resistant. A leader may also ask a member to leave the group because her needs may be so contrary to the purpose of the group that she would receive no benefit from it. For example, if a member of a parent education group kept bringing up personal problems dealing with her self-concept, marriage, and weight, it would be best if that member were not a part of that group. After determining that a member should not be a part of the group, the leader must next consider how and when to tell that member. Sometimes the task can be quite easy. For example, the leader could meet with the member after the group and say something like the following:

LEADER: Teresa, it seems that the things you really need from a group are not what this group is about. Maybe you have even wondered whether or not this group could be helpful to you. Given that your needs will not be served by this group, I think it might be best if we found you another alternative. Perhaps we could locate a more appropriate group for you or refer you to someone whom you could see on an individual basis. What do you think?

Another reason for asking a member to leave is that he has been very disruptive. Certainly there must be attempts to bring the disruptive member under control before asking the member to leave. However, if the member continues

to disrupt and intrude on the rights of the other members, the leader should ask that member to leave the group. Ideally, it is best to do so at the end of a session or during a dyad. This prevents a power struggle from occurring in front of the other members. For example, at the end of a session, the leader could say, in private, something like:

LEADER: *(Calmly)* Patty, I must speak to you very frankly for a moment. Whether or not you are aware of it, you are disrupting the group to the point that I'm afraid the other members are not receiving any benefit. All attempts to halt your disruption have been to no avail. I think it would be best if you did not return. It is my responsibility to refer you to another group or to an individual therapist, and I will be glad to do so.

If the disruption is so severe that waiting until a break or the end of the group is not possible, the leader must act immediately so that the session may resume and be of benefit to the other members. In this case, the leader must explain the action to the entire group and then say something like, "Steve, I must ask you to leave," or "Steve, you have disrupted the group too much; please leave."

Of course, the strategies mentioned here apply to group situations where the members can be removed; that is, they are volunteers in the group or the setting, which gives the leader the freedom to remove a member if necessary. In a setting where the members must attend and there is no freedom to remove a member, the leader may ask that the member sit in silence or sit outside the circle of working members.

Dealing with Prejudiced, Narrow-Minded, or Insensitive Members

Occasionally, a leader will have to deal with a member with a very narrow or prejudiced view of the world, one who tries to act as a moralist or preacher. This is a difficult situation, because one purpose of most groups is to hear different points of view and learn to be tolerant of others. However, there is a point when a member who cannot refrain from preaching and judging others may need to be removed from the group. It is not good leadership to always let members have their say. For instance, if a woman is talking about having an affair and another member starts in about how evil and wrong it is, the leader should quickly cut off that member. In a case like this, the leader must politely ask the member to try to understand that others have different views. If this does not work and the member insists on being heard, the leader may need to ask the member to leave the group. The leadership rule is to be tolerant of members' differences and intervene only when a member's comments are so prejudiced that they could be

harmful. In the following example, the leader did not hesitate to quickly cut off the member who was not being sensitive.

EXAMPLE

SUSAN: I know I am young and all, but for the last year or so, I have been really questioning if there is a God. I am not sure how others of you feel, but I don't think I believe in God. This has me worried and I end up often fighting with my mom about this.

DONNA: *(Angrily and with a condescending voice)* How can you not believe in God!

SUSAN: I am confused, and it does not feel good because all my life I have thought of God as an important part of my life, and now, I don't know what to think. It just doesn't make sense to me, especially when I talk with these friends of my brother who are in college and studying world religions.

DONNA: That's crazy. What do they know compared to what older people know! Where do you think we came from?

LEADER: *(In a calm, caring voice)* Donna, try to be helpful to Susan. Tune in to her.

DONNA: Maybe you are just going to the wrong church. You should come to my church! I just can't believe you are questioning if there is a God. My father says that anyone who doesn't believe in God is ...

LEADER: *(Firmly)* Wait a minute. Donna, if you cannot tune in to her pain, then you need to not talk. Your comments are not helpful. Susan, I want you to look at other members and realize that we do understand how hard this is for you. *(She looks around and sees very concerned faces; Donna is now looking down. The leader stays with Susan.)* I feel that we can help you. Are you willing to talk about it some more?

SUSAN: Yes.

In this example, the leader had to intervene quickly because the member was being insensitive to the situation. If the member persists, the leader may have to talk with the member or even ask her to leave the group if she is not open to viewpoints different from hers.

Concluding Comments

As a group leader, you will be faced with many difficult members and many difficult situations, such as the chronic talker, the dominator, the distracter, the negative member, the resistant member, the crying member, or the member who is out to get the leader. For each of these situations, there are different skills

and techniques that can be helpful. For resistant clients, it is important to distinguish whether the member is resistant to being in the group or to changing.

For crying members, the leader has to know when the tears should be supported and when they should be ignored. A very important thing to understand is that there will be times when you will have to ask a member to leave the group because of the dynamics that he is creating. When faced with these situations (and you will be faced with them if you lead groups), we suggest you refer back to this chapter. And remember, these problems are not unique to your group or a reflection on your leadership.

ACTIVITIES

1. Think of at least three different situations you have been in where there was a problem member or student. What would you have done if you had been in charge of dealing with that person?
2. Consider the problem situations of a crying member, a dominator, or a member who is out to get the leader. Which one of these will be hardest for you to handle? Why? Talk with your fellow students or colleagues about this, and hear which one would be hardest for them.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

View again videos 3.2 and 8.2, and watch how the leader deals with these difficult members. Try to picture what would happen if the leader did not intervene.